



MANDRAKE
The mandrake root, once used in medicines, sometimes looks almost human. It was usually pulled up by a dog, because, according to an old superstition, the root would shriek as it came out of the ground. Any human who heard the noise would die.

Potions and poisons

IN ANCIENT TIMES, plants were the main source of medicines. By trial and error, it was discovered that particular species could cure certain diseases. These plants were often grown in special gardens, and their details noted in books called herbals. Today, many plants are still used by the pharmaceutical industry. The chemicals they produce may be poisonous in large quantities, but small amounts can prove very useful in the treatment of some illnesses.

The search for new medicines continues today, and every year pharmacologists examine thousands of plants from all over the world.

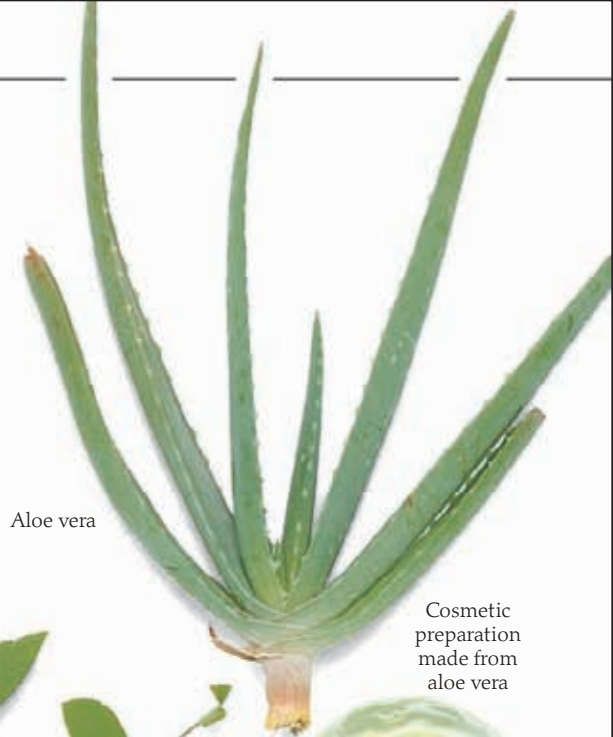
OUT OF THE EAST

In China, ginseng has been prized for about 5,000 years. The powdered root has a stimulant effect and can aid recovery from illness. Ginseng is grown commercially and is now sold all over the world.



Red ginseng root from Korea

Aloe vera



Cosmetic preparation made from aloe vera



Jojoba



COSMETIC EFFECT

Plants are often used in cosmetics for their pleasant smell, or soothing oils. Two plants that are popular in today's cosmetics are jojoba and aloe vera. Both live in dry places and contain oils that help to keep skin soft.

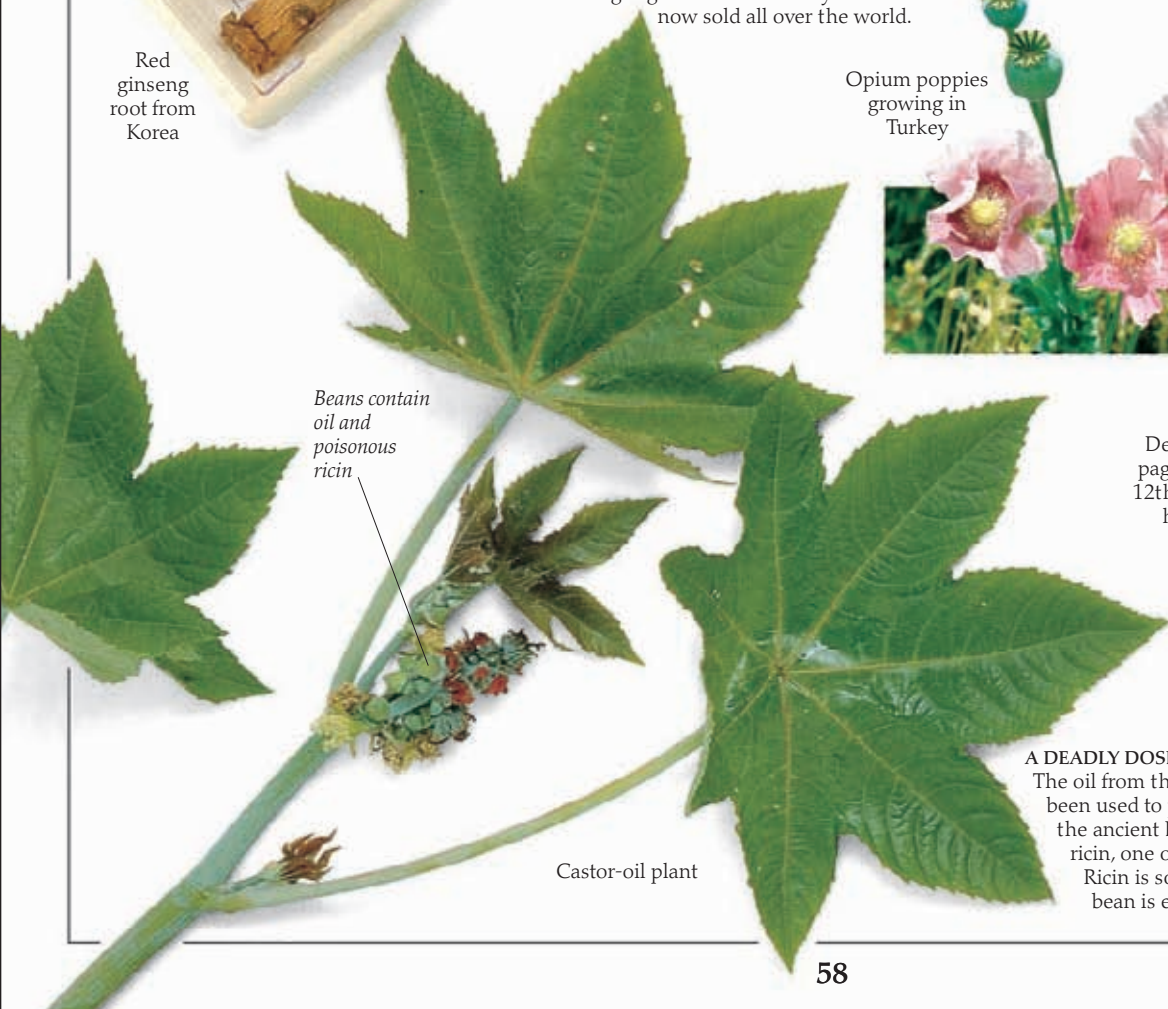
THE OPIUM POPPY

For thousands of years opium poppies have been grown as a source of drugs. Raw opium is the poppy's dried sap. It oozes out of the unripe seed head after it has been scarred with a knife. Opium is used in the manufacture of morphine, codeine, and heroin—drugs that can be deadly if misused.

Opium poppies growing in Turkey



Beans contain oil and poisonous ricin



Castor-oil plant

Detail of a page from a 12th-century herbal



A DEADLY DOSE

The oil from the beans of the castor-oil plant has been used to purify the system since the days of the ancient Egyptians. The beans also contain ricin, one of the most potent poisons known. Ricin is so powerful that, if eaten, just one bean is enough to kill an adult.